

How to Use This Binder

Your central command center for managing an owner-builder construction project — every form, checklist, and log you need to keep professional records from first permit to final inspection.

Keep this binder on-site and accessible at all times. It works because it is paper: no battery, no signal, nothing to load — and you can hand any page to a sub or an inspector.

SETTING UP

What you'll need:

- 3-ring binder — heavy-duty 2" or 3" with D-rings
- 8 divider tabs, labeled for each section
- Clear sheet protectors (about 50) for blank masters and frequently used references
- Three-hole punch, sticky notes, and page flags

Print everything double-sided at an office-supply store (about \$40-60), punch, and assemble in numbered order: cover, this guide, table of contents, then Sections 1 through 8 with a tab at each section title page. Slide the spine label into the binder's spine pocket.

Editable versions included: the ZIP also contains Word (.docx) versions of the contract documents and Excel (.xlsx) versions of the budget and tracking spreadsheets — customize them with your project details, then print and punch the results into the binder.

THE EIGHT SECTIONS

Section 1 — Project Planning & Foundation. Use during pre-construction and foundation work. Start here: master timeline and budget first.

Section 2 — Contracts & Legal Documents. Subcontractor agreements, change orders, lien waivers, and payment records. Update after every transaction.

Section 3 — Rough-In Phase. Framing and rough-in checklists for electrical, plumbing, and HVAC inspections.

Section 4 — Systems Installation. Final installation and testing of mechanical, electrical, and plumbing systems before closing walls.

Section 5 — Finish Work. Drywall, doors, trim, flooring, cabinets, and paint.

Section 6 — Daily Operations. Daily logs, deliveries, weather delays, and safety incidents — the section you'll touch every working day.

Section 7 — Budget & Expenses. Expense tracking, receipts, cost-overrun analysis, and final reconciliation.

Section 8 — Quick Reference Guides. Code requirements, span tables, calculators, and emergency contacts.

WHEN TO USE EACH FORM

Daily: Daily Job Site Log (6.1); Material Delivery & Storage Log (6.3) whenever a delivery arrives.

Before each phase: Review that section's checklists so you know what's coming.

Before every inspection: Complete the matching inspection checklist — walk it with a pen before you call the inspector.

When hiring subs: Subcontractor Agreement (2.1); track payments with the Payment Draw Schedule (2.4).

For every expense: Log it in the Expense Tracking Sheets (7.1); file the receipt (7.2).

When anything changes: Document it immediately with a Change Order Form (2.2).

HABITS THAT KEEP YOU ORGANIZED

- Set aside 15 minutes at the end of each day to update logs and file receipts — consistency beats perfection.
- Photocopy (or reprint) blank forms before you use the last one; keep blank masters in sheet protectors.
- Take photos to supplement written logs and reference them by date in the daily log.
- Review the master timeline every Sunday and adjust for actual progress.